handcuffing the army and endangering the public. Yitzhak Yosef, one of Israel's two chief rabbis, repeated the Talmudic injunction, "If someone comes to kill you, rise up and kill him first." Soldiers shouldn't worry about the courts, "or if some chief of staff says something else," he said in a sermon, a clear rebuke to Eizenkot.[2]

Netanyahu kept quiet for four days after Eizenkot's speech, then finally dismissed the furor as "pointless". It was a half-hearted defense of his top general, but it was enough to silence the controversy—until it roared back after the Hebron shooting. The prime minister's initial statement, issued hours after the incident, declared that Azaria "does not represent the values of the IDF [Israel Defense Forces]." The backlash was immediate: social media—including the WhatsApp groups favored by Likud members—was filled with angry invective that accused Netanyahu of abandoning Azaria to "the Arabs" and "the left". Right-wing activists circulated a photo of Israeli Defense Minister Moshe Ya'alon, in the crosshairs of a gun, with the words "politically eliminated" written in red below.

The prime minister read the political winds, and on 31 March he made an unusual phone call to Azaria's father, Charlie. "As the father of a soldier, I understand your distress," Netanyahu told him. "The soldiers are forced to make decisions in the field, in real time, under stress and conditions of uncertainty. This is not a simple reality."[3]

Yet this was a charitable interpretation. The shooting didn't happen in real time; the B'Tselem video showed Azaria standing around for several minutes before he pulled the trigger. He had told other soldiers that Sharif "deserved to die", according to army investigators. His Facebook page revealed a history of racist posts, including his support for Meir Kahane, the right-wing rabbi whose political party (Kach) was banned as a terrorist organization in Israel in 1994.

Some Israeli commentators were incredulous. Since when do heads of government pay condolence calls to the relatives of manslaughter suspects? It particularly infuriated Ya'alon and the army brass, because it seemed to throw the military prosecution under the bus. They delivered their response on 4 May, Holocaust Remembrance Day. General Yair Golan, the deputy chief of staff, warned that the "disgusting trends" in Israeli society—racism, "hatred of the other"—were reminiscent of events in Europe, "particularly Germany", on the eve of World War II.